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Credit - Drishti Ias

Adaptation Gap Report 2026

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For Prelims: Adaptation , Nationally Determined Contributions , National Adaptation Plans , Glasgow Climate Pact , Fund for Responding to Loss and Damage , Paris Agreement ,

For Mains: Adaptation vs. Mitigation , Energy Transition, **Fund for Responding to Loss and Damage , Paris Agreement .**

Source: DD

Why in News?

The **United Nations Environment Programme (UNEP)** has released the **Adaptation Gap Report 2026** , titled **" *Ready? Not. Climate impacts will not wait. Adaptation finance must rise.*"** The report warns that **adaptation finance** continues to fall far short of needs, implementation is constrained by institutional barriers, and loss and damage are mounting as climate impacts intensify.

Summary

- The UNEP Adaptation Gap Report 2026 highlights the widening gap between climate adaptation needs and available finance, with developing countries facing rising debt burdens and climate-related losses.
- It calls for predictable, grant-based climate finance, stronger support for the Loss and Damage Fund, and climate justice based on CBDR-RC.

What are the Key Highlights of the Adaptation Gap Report 2026?

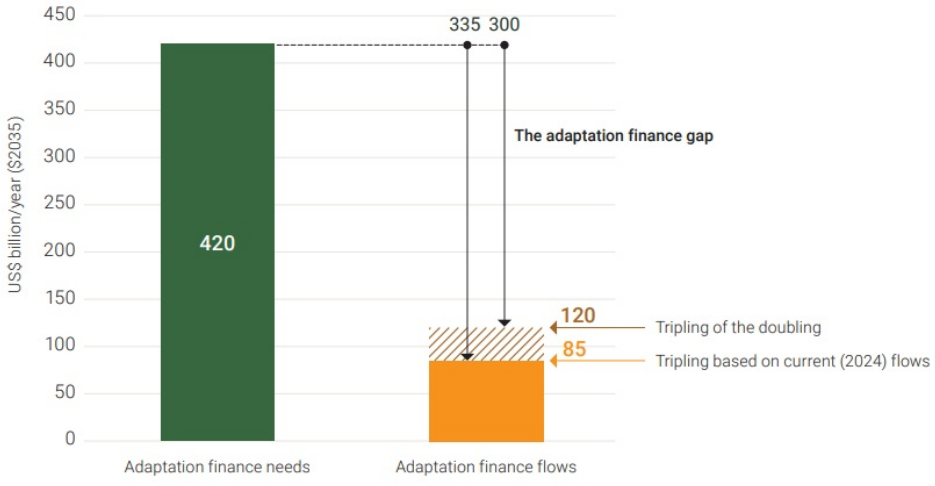
The Adaptation Finance Deficit

- **Estimated Needs:** Based on the latest **Nationally Determined Contributions (NDCs) and National**

Adaptation Plans (NAPs) **of 155 developing countries,** climate adaptation finance needs are estimated at USD 255–328 billion annually over the next decade, reaching around **USD 305 billion per year by 2035.** Including private-sector needs could nearly double the requirement.

  - Least Developed Countries (LDCs) and Small Island Developing States (SIDS) require USD 40–50 billion annually for climate adaptation, equivalent to **3–4% of their GDP,** nearly twice the relative needs of upper-middle-income developing countries.

- **Current Flows:** International public adaptation finance reached USD **28.2 - 31.7 billion in 2024,** falling short of the trajectory needed to meet the **Glasgow Climate Pact target.**
  - **Glasgow Climate Pact (COP26, 2021)** urged developed countries to at least double adaptation finance from 2019 levels by 2025 (about USD 40 billion).
  - The report notes that the **2025 target remains achievable** , provided adequate funding is mobilised through Multilateral Development Banks (MDBs) and bilateral development flows.
- **Rising Debt Burden:** While 80–90% of funding for LDCs and SIDS is concessional, **55% of all adaptation finance to developing countries in 2024 was delivered as loans.**
  - Non-concessional loans account for approximately half of all adaptation lending, mainly provided by MDBs to middle-income countries
- **The "Tripling" Shortfall:** The COP30 proposal to triple adaptation finance by 2035 would **yield USD 85-120 billion annually.**
  - Adjusted for inflation, 2035 needs rise from USD 305 billion to **USD 420 billion** , so tripling would meet only **20–29% of needs** , leaving a gap of roughly **USD 300–335 billion** .
- **South-South Cooperation:** Financial support between developing nations is actively growing, jumping from USD 3.8 billion in 2019 to USD 9.6 billion in 2024.
- **Limits of Private Adaptation Finance:** Private finance mobilised through international public adaptation finance doubled from **USD 1.5 billion in 2019 to USD 3 billion in 2024.**
  - However, private finance may bridge only **15–20% of the financing gap for public-oriented adaptation needs,** underscoring the continued importance of public finance.
- **Effective Adaptation:** The report notes that the adaptation implementation requires more than finance. It depends on **eight institutional factors,** including clear legal frameworks, defined mandates, intergovernmental coordination, stakeholder participation, accountability, knowledge-sharing, and effective finance mobilisation, alongside addressing legacy dependencies.

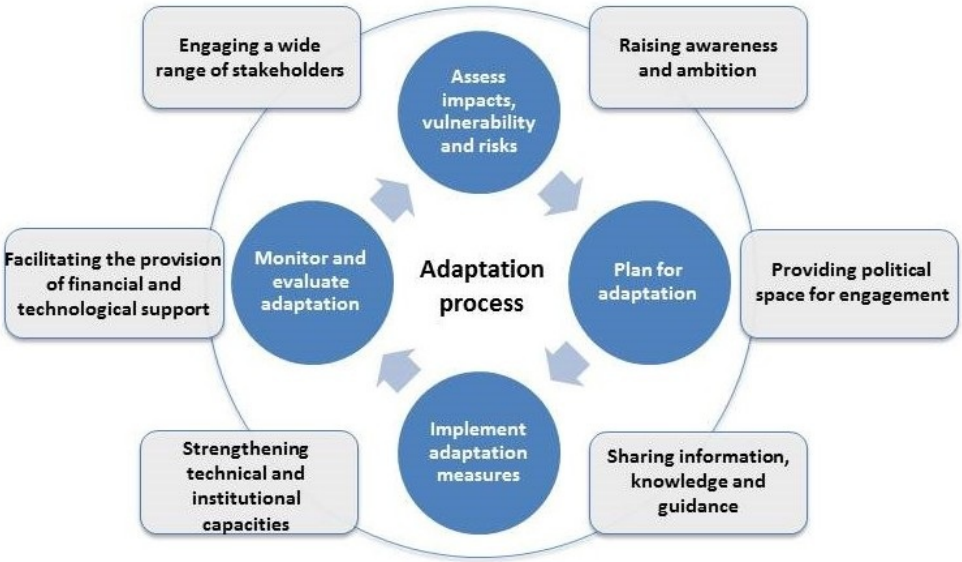


Loss and Damage (L&D)

- **Disproportionate Impact:** Between 2020 and 2025, 99% of the 765 million people affected by floods and landslides lived in low- and middle-income countries.
- **The Data Gap:** Among 118 countries assessed, 89% recognise **Loss and Damage (L&D)** in their NDCs or NAPs, 54% have information systems to track it and 38% have relevant legal frameworks
  - Only 27% of nearly 240,000 recorded extreme-heat deaths during 2020–2025 were reported in lower-income countries, potentially reflecting underreporting, limited observation capacity and differences in preparedness.
  - This severely masks non-economic losses like cultural heritage, mental health, and biodiversity degradation.
- **Severe Funding Shortfall:** 119 developing countries sought USD 2.8 billion from the **United Nations' Fund for Responding to Loss and Damage (FRLD),** far exceeding its initial funding envelope of USD 342 million.

What is Climate Adaptation?

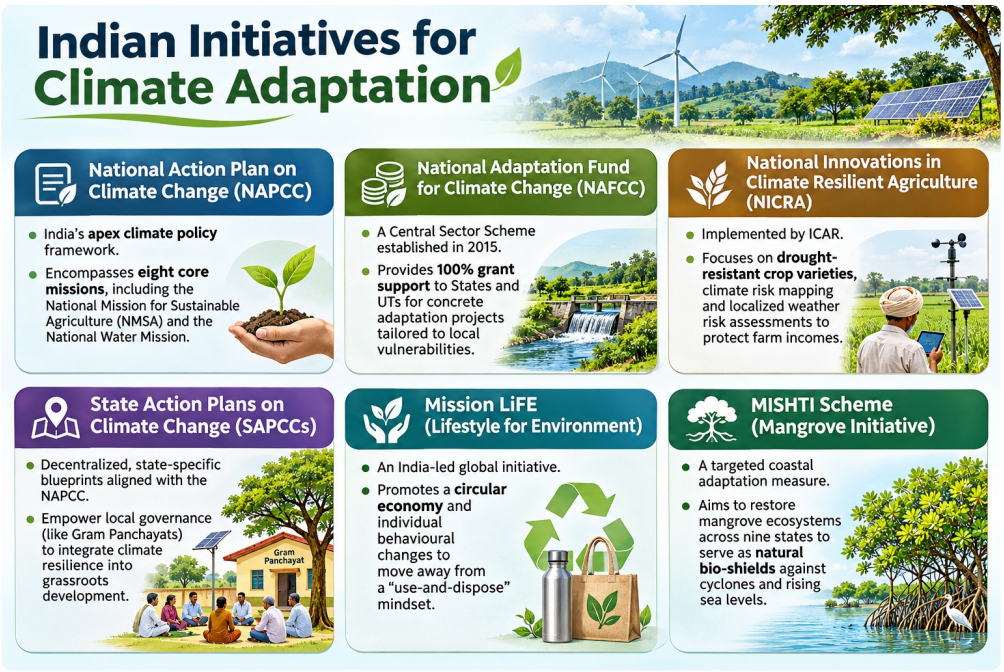
- **About:** Adaptation refers to adjustments in **ecological, social or economic systems** in response to actual or expected climatic stimuli and their effects.
  - It refers to changes in processes, practices and structures to moderate **potential damages or to benefit from opportunities associated with climate change.**



- **Global Adaptation Mechanisms under UNFCCC:**
  - **Global Goal on Adaptation (GGA):** Established under **Article 7.1 of the Paris Agreement** , the **GGA** is a collective global commitment designed to enhance adaptive capacity, strengthen systemic resilience, and reduce macroeconomic vulnerability to climate impacts.
  - **Least Developed Countries Expert Group (LEG):** Established in 2001, LEG is mandated to provide technical guidance and financial support to vulnerable nations for formulating and implementing **NAPs** .
  - **Adaptation Committee (AC):** Established in 2010, the AC acts as the **apex global voice** on adaptation, providing expert technical guidance to ensure coherent worldwide implementation of the **Paris Agreement** .
  - **Nairobi Work Programme (NWP):** Operates the **Adaptation Knowledge Portal** , serving as the central knowledge-to-action hub for identifying global climate vulnerabilities and sharing resilience

strategies.

- **India's Stance on Climate Adaptation:**
  - **Climate Justice & CBDR-RC:** India anchors its position on **Common But Differentiated Responsibilities and Respective Capabilities** , demanding that developed nations provide predictable, highly concessional, and publicly funded climate finance.
  - **Voluntary GGA Indicators:** India maintains that performance indicators under the GGA must remain voluntary, country-driven, and non-prescriptive, opposing their use as **conditions for accessing multilateral climate finance.**



Click here to Read: **Blueprint for India's Climate Adaptation**

What Measures are Needed to Strengthen Global Climate Adaptation?

- **Integrate with NCQG Framework:** Embed robust adaptation tracking mechanisms within the **New Collective Quantified Goal (NCQG)** to ensure the transparent mobilization of private capital, moving beyond the unfulfilled ambitions of the **Glasgow Climate Pact** .
- **Restructure MDB Lending:** Reform the lending architecture of **Multilateral Development Banks (MDBs)** to prioritize grant-based, highly concessional financing for the Global South, thereby preventing **climate-driven sovereign debt crises.**
- **Recapitalize the L&D Fund:** Simplify operational access to the **FRLD** to address severe capitalization shortfalls and meet the immediate needs of vulnerable nations.
  - Mandate the creation of dedicated national **Loss and Damage Information Systems** to systematically quantify cascading systemic risks and evaluate critical **non-economic losses** , such as cultural heritage and biodiversity degradation.
- **Decentralized Domestic Mainstreaming:** Strengthen grassroots resilience by aligning apex national policies like the **National Action Plan on Climate Change (NAPCC)** with decentralized **State Action Plans on Climate Change (SAPCCs)** , specifically prioritizing the protection of agrarian economies and coastal ecosystems.

- **Address Institutional Deficits:** Strengthen legal mandates, intergovernmental coordination, community participation and independent monitoring mechanisms to translate adaptation plans into effective implementation.

Conclusion

Addressing climate impacts requires predictable, grant-based adaptation finance, stronger funding under the New Collective Quantified Goal, and recapitalisation of the Loss and Damage Fund. Upholding climate justice and CBDR-RC is vital to building resilience across the Global South.

> ***Drishti Mains Question:***
>
> The widening climate adaptation finance gap reflects not merely a shortage of resources but also inequalities in the global climate governance framework. Discuss.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What is the UNEP Adaptation Gap Report 2026?
It assesses the gap between developing countries' climate adaptation needs and available finance, highlighting challenges in implementation and loss and damage.

2. What is the estimated global adaptation finance requirement by 2035?
Developing countries require around US$305 billion annually, rising to approximately US$420 billion in 2035 prices.

3. What is the Global Goal on Adaptation (GGA)?
Established under Article 7.1 of the Paris Agreement, the GGA aims to enhance adaptive capacity, strengthen resilience and reduce vulnerability to climate change.

4. What is the Fund for Responding to Loss and Damage (FRLD)?
It is a climate finance mechanism established to assist vulnerable developing countries in addressing economic and non-economic losses caused by climate change.

5. What is India's position on climate adaptation finance?
India advocates climate justice and CBDR-RC, demanding predictable, publicly funded and highly concessional climate finance from developed countries.

[Watch Video on YouTube: ▶ **https://www.youtube.com/embed/ffUixFyINZ0**]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions (PYQs)

Prelims

Q.1 In the context of India’s preparation for Climate-Smart Agriculture, consider the following statements: (2021)

1. The ‘Climate-Smart Village’ approach in India is a part of a project led by the Climate Change, Agriculture and Food Security (CCAFS), an international research programme.
2. The project of CCAFS is carried out under Consultative Group on International Agricultural Research (CGIAR) headquartered in France.

3. The International Crops Research Institute for the Semi-Arid Tropics (ICRISAT) in India is one of the CGIAR's research centres.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

(a) 1 and 2 only
(b) 2 and 3 only
(c) 1 and 3 only
(d) 1, 2 and 3

Ans: (d)

Q.2 Which of the following best describes/describe the aim of 'Green India Mission' of the Government of India? (2016)

1. Incorporating environmental benefits and costs into the Union and State Budgets thereby implementing the 'green accounting'.
2. Launching the second green revolution to enhance agricultural output so as to ensure food security to one and all in the future.
3. Restoring and enhancing forest cover and responding to climate change by a combination of adaptation and mitigation measures.

Select the correct answer using the code given below.

(a) 1 only
(b) 2 and 3 only
(c) 3 only
(d) 1, 2 and 3

Ans: (c)

Q.3 With reference to 'Global Climate Change Alliance', which of the following statements is/are correct? (2017)

1. It is an initiative of the European Union.
2. It provides technical and financial support to targeted developing countries to integrate climate change into their development policies and budgets.
3. It is coordinated by World Resources Institute (WRI) and World Business Council for Sustainable Development (WBCSD).

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

(a) 1 and 2 only
(b) 3 only
(c) 2 and 3 only
(d) 1, 2 and 3

Ans: (a)

Mains

Q.1 Describe the major outcomes of the 26th session of the Conference of the Parties (COP) to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC). What are the commitments made by India in this conference? **(2021)**

Q.2 'Climate Change' is a global problem. How will India be affected by climate change? How Himalayan and coastal states of India will be affected by climate change? **(2017)**

OBC Creamy Layer: Supreme Court on Parental Income and Reservation

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For Prelims: Creamy layer , Other Backward Classes , Article 15, Article 16 , Supreme Court of India

For Mains: Constitutional provisions relating to affirmative action and reservation, Substantive equality versus formal equality

Source: IE

Why in News?

The **Supreme Court of India** reaffirmed its **Union of India v. Rohith Nathan (2026)** judgment, which established that the **' creamy layer ' status of Other Backward Classes (OBCs) cannot be determined exclusively by parental income.**

- In a significant clarification following a plea from the Centre, the Court stated that this ruling will operate prospectively. While it will not alter past service allocations, appointments, or seniority lists, it will strictly govern pending allocations, including the **Civil Services Examination (CSE) 2025.**

Summary

- The Supreme Court reaffirmed that OBC creamy layer status cannot be determined solely by parental income, emphasising occupational status and the original 1993 DoPT guidelines.
- The ruling will apply prospectively, covering pending allocations, including CSE 2025, without reopening concluded appointments or seniority lists.

What is the Supreme Court’s Clarification on OBC Creamy Layer Ruling?

- **The 1993 DoPT Guidelines:** Following the landmark ***Indra Sawhney*** **judgment (1992)** (upheld OBC reservation, introduced the Creamy Layer rule), the Department of Personnel and Training (DoPT)

established criteria to identify the 'creamy layer' based on parental occupational rank and status (Categories I to V) and a residual Income/Wealth test (Category VI).

  - Crucially, this original framework **explicitly excluded salary and agricultural income** from the Rs 8 lakh income threshold.

- **The 2004 Clarificatory Letter:** A controversial 2004 government directive mandated that for **Public Sector Undertaking (PSU)** and private sector employees whose posts lacked **established "equivalence" with government ranks** the creamy layer status would be evaluated by **aggregating their actual salary income** .
- **The March 2026 Verdict (*Union of India v. Rohith Nathan*):** The Supreme Court struck down the 2004 letter, ruling that an OBC candidate's creamy layer status **cannot be determined solely by parental income brackets** . The Court firmly established that:
  - Determinations must strictly adhere to the status parameters outlined in the original 1993 DoPT OM. Since affirmative action is designed to address historical socio-educational disadvantage rather than mere poverty, relying solely on economic criteria such as equating salary income with social advancement causes **"hostile discrimination" against middle-class salaried families.**
- **SC Clarification (Prospective Application):** The Court clarified that the March 2026 judgment **will not operate retrospectively** . It will not reopen concluded selections, past appointments, or established seniority lists, as doing so would trigger massive administrative chaos.
  - However, the revised and constitutionally sound criteria will strictly govern all **pending allocations** .

Concept of the 'Creamy Layer'

- **Genesis:** The concept was introduced by the Supreme Court in the **Indra Sawhney Case (1992)** . While upholding **27% reservation for OBCs** , the Court directed the exclusion of socially/economically advanced sections within them (the 'creamy layer') to ensure the **benefits reach the most deserving.**
  - It is based on the idea of **"Relative Equality" -** treating unequals as equals (a wealthy person vs. a poor person within the same caste) would violate the right to equality.
- **Ram Nandan Prasad Committee (1993):** This committee was constituted to identify the specific objective socio-economic criteria, which formed the basis of the 1993 DoPT Office Memorandum.
- **Criteria for Exclusion:**
  - **Constitutional/Group A & B Posts:** Children of the President, Judges, Class I/II (Group A/B) officers, Armed forces colonels, etc., automatically fall in the creamy layer based on **status** , not income.
  - **Income Test:** The income limit is currently capped at **Rs 8 Lakhs annually** (having evolved from the original Rs 1 lakh in 1993, with the last revision occurring in 2017).
    - Candidates whose parents have a gross annual income of ₹8 Lakhs or more for **three consecutive years** are classified under the creamy layer.
    - However, income derived from *salaries or agricultural land* is not clubbed into this Rs 8 lakh limit.

What are the Concerns Associated with the

Application of the Creamy Layer Principle?

- **Failure to Establish 'Equivalence of Posts':** Since 1993, the government has repeatedly delayed mapping roles in PSUs, Banks, and the private sector to their equivalent Group A, B, C, and D government ranks.
  - This administrative failure creates massive ambiguity in determining the occupational status of candidates' parents.
- **Stagnant Income Ceiling:** The residual income threshold (currently Rs 8 Lakhs) was last revised in 2017.
  - Failing to periodically upgrade this limit in tandem with **inflation** and rising **per capita income results** in the unfair exclusion of genuinely marginalized candidates.
- **Dominance of Forward OBC Castes:** The creamy layer filter alone is insufficient to ensure equitable distribution of benefits.
  - Treating the entire OBC category as a **monolith allows a few dominant castes to corner maximum reservation benefits,** leaving the Most Backward Classes (MBCs) deprived of a systemic flaw highlighted by the **Justice G. Rohini Commission (2017)** .
- **Ambiguity in the Agricultural Wealth Test:** While agricultural income is excluded, the creamy layer criteria include a **strict land-holding test** (e.g., owning irrigated land equal to or more than 85% of the state's statutory ceiling area).
  - Because land ceiling laws and the definitions of **'irrigated land' vary drastically from state to state,** it creates deep bureaucratic inconsistencies and unequal standards for OBC certification across the country.
- **Debate Over Extension to SC/ST Categories:** Unlike OBCs, SC/ST reservations are rooted in **addressing historical untouchability and absolute social exclusion** .
  - Critics argue that applying economic filters risks leaving reserved posts unfilled and ignores the reality that economic advancement does not automatically erase deep-rooted caste-based discrimination.

Way Forward

- **Dynamic Revision of Income Ceiling:** The government should institutionalize an automatic, data-driven mechanism to revise the income threshold every three years.
  - Linking this limit to the **Consumer Price Index (CPI) or national per capita income** will prevent inflation from unfairly penalizing marginalized applicants.
- **Uniform Creamy-layer Framework:** The government should establish transparent and consistent criteria for determining equivalence between government, PSU and private-sector posts.
  - The Supreme Court clarified that creamy-layer policy formulation and post equivalence fall within the domain of the executive and legislature, subject to constitutional principles, and declined to prescribe a deadline for this exercise.
- **Prioritize Substantive Equality:** Future policy formulations by the executive must strictly align with the original constitutional intent of **Article 15(4)** and **Article 16(4)** ensuring that economic criteria (like salaries) do not overshadow the primary goal of addressing historical socio-educational backwardness.
- **Targeted Capacity Building for the Non-Creamy Layer (OBC-NCL):** The government should utilize institutions like the **National Career Service Centres (NCSCs)** to provide focused training in soft skills, professional communication, and interview etiquette.
  - Bridging this "cultural gap" ensures that marginalized OBC-NCL candidates can confidently clear high-

stakes personality tests and secure higher-level administrative posts.

Drishti Mains Question:

How can India reconcile the principles of social justice, equality of opportunity and targeted welfare delivery while reforming its reservation framework?

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What is the creamy layer principle, and which judgment introduced it?
The Supreme Court introduced it in the Indra Sawhney v. Union of India (1992) judgment to exclude socially advanced sections among OBCs from reservation benefits.

2. What are the constitutional provisions governing OBC reservation?
Article 15(4): Enables special provisions for the advancement of socially and educationally backward classes.

Article 16(4): Enables reservation in public employment for backward classes inadequately represented in state services.

3. Which committee recommended the criteria for identifying the OBC creamy layer?
The Ram Nandan Prasad Committee (1993) recommended objective criteria, forming the basis of the 1993 DoPT Office Memorandum.

4. What is the current income threshold for OBC creamy layer exclusion?
The income threshold is ₹8 lakh annually for three consecutive years under the applicable criteria. Salary and agricultural income are excluded from the residual income test, subject to occupational and other applicable criteria.

[Watch Video on YouTube: ▶ https://www.youtube.com/embed/neqbxy4hSVM]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions (PYQs)

Prelims

Q. Consider the following organizations/bodies in India: (2023)

1. The National Commission for Backward Classes
2. The National Human Rights Commission
3. The National Law Commission
4. The National Consumer Disputes Redressal Commission

How many of the above constitutional bodies?

(a) Only one

(b) Only two

(c) Only three

(d) All four

Ans: (a)

Mains

Q. Whether the National Commission for Scheduled Castes (NCSC) can enforce the implementation of constitutional reservation for the Scheduled Castes in the religious minority institutions? Examine. **(2018)**

Q. What are the two major legal initiatives by the State since Independence addressing discrimination against Scheduled Tribes (STs). **(2017)**

Annual Survey of Industries FY 2024-25

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Source: PIB

Why in News?

The **Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI)** released the **Annual Survey of Industries (ASI) results for FY 2024-25** . The data highlights strong resilience in Indian manufacturing, with the **manufacturing corporate sector recording a Gross Value Added (GVA) growth of 9.28%** over the previous year.

What are the Key Highlights of ASI 2024-25?

- **Robust GVA & Output Growth:** The **GVA** of India's manufacturing corporate sector recorded a strong **9.28% growth in FY 2024–25** when compared directly to the **FY 2023–24** baseline.
  - Furthermore, the **Net Value Added per Factory** increased by **6.59% in 2024–25** against **2023–24** , indicating **higher per-unit profitability and economic productivity.**
- **Factory Network Expansion:** The total number of operating factories in the corporate sector expanded by **3.45% in FY 2024–25** compared to the **FY 2023–24** figures, reflecting steady formalization under initiatives like **Make in India.**
- **Employment Generation & Labor Productivity:** The total number of persons engaged in the manufacturing corporate sector saw a **7.57% growth in 2024–25** relative to **2023–24** .
  - Importantly, labor efficiency improved, with the **GVA per Person Engaged growing by 2.25% in 2024–25** .
- **Surge in Capital Investments:** Signifying a boost in **Gross Fixed Capital Formation (GFCF) ,** the registered manufacturing sector recorded a **7.25% growth in the Gross Value of Plant & Machinery in 2024–25** , pointing toward industrial capacity expansion.
- **Top 5 States Dominating GVA: Maharashtra, Gujarat, Tamil Nadu, Karnataka, and Uttar Pradesh** emerged as the **undisputed industrial hubs,** collectively accounting for **over 54% of the nation's total manufacturing GVA** for the **2024–25** period.
- **Major Employment Drivers:** Labor-intensive sectors remain the backbone of job creation.
  - **Food Products, Textiles, Basic Metals, Motor Vehicles, and Wearing Apparel** together contributed **over 41% of India’s total manufacturing employment** during the **2024–25** period.
- **Capital vs. Net Value Added (NVA) Disparity:** In **2024–25** , large factories (investment over Rs 10 crore) made up only **15.84%** of all operating units but commanded **87.42% of total fixed capital** and generated **78.07% of total NVA** .
  - Conversely, MSME units (investment up to Rs 5 crore) constituted **78.69%** of total factories but contributed a mere **17.61% to the NVA** , highlighting the severe structural inequalities in India's industrial output.

What is the Annual Survey of Industries (ASI)?

- **About:** ASI is the **principal source of industrial statistics in India.** It provides statistical information to assess and evaluate the changes in the growth, composition, and structure of the organized manufacturing sector.
- **Nodal Agency:** It is conducted by the **National Statistical Office (NSO)** under the **Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI).**
  - The survey is conducted under the **Collection of Statistics Act, 2008 (amended in 2017) and its 2024 Rules.**
- **Coverage:** It covers all factories registered under **Sections 2(m)(i) and 2(m)(ii) of the Factories Act, 1948** (factories employing 10 or more workers with power, or 20 or more workers without power).
  - Several states (including Maharashtra, Rajasthan, Gujarat, UP, and Bihar) have amended the Factories Act, revising the criteria to **20+ workers (with power)** and **40+ workers (without power)** .
  - It also covers Bidi and cigar manufacturing establishments registered under the **Bidi & Cigar Workers (Conditions of Employment) Act,1966.**
  - Beyond the Factories Act, ASI includes units with **100 or more employees registered in the**

Business Register of Establishments (BRE) under other laws (e.g., **Companies Act 2013** , **Societies Registration Act, 1860** , **Khadi & Village Industries Board**).

- For the Union Territories of **Ladakh and Lakshadweep** , the BRE employee criteria has been significantly **relaxed to "10 or more" employees** .
- The survey also covers electricity undertakings engaged in generation, transmission and distribution that are not registered with the Central Electricity Authority (CEA).

- **Primary Units of Enumeration:** The survey uses specific units based on the sector: a factory (manufacturing), a workshop (repair services), an undertaking/licensee (electricity/water/gas), and an establishment (bidi & cigar).
  - Owners operating multiple units within the same State and same industry group are allowed to file a single consolidated return (a common practice for bidi/cigar units and public sector undertakings).
- **Significance and Data Collection** : ASI provides essential inputs for National Accounts Statistics at national and state levels and follows an establishment-based approach, collecting data entirely through a dedicated web portal.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What is the Annual Survey of Industries (ASI)?
ASI is India's principal source of industrial statistics, assessing the growth, composition and structure of the organised manufacturing sector.

2. Which agency conducts the Annual Survey of Industries?
The National Statistical Office (NSO) under the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI) conducts the ASI.

3. Under which law is the ASI conducted?
It is conducted under the Collection of Statistics Act, 2008, amended in 2017, along with the Collection of Statistics Rules, 2024.

4. What are the key eligibility criteria for factories covered under ASI?
Under the Factories Act, 1948, factories employing 10 or more workers with power or 20 or more without power are covered, subject to applicable state amendments.

5. Which states account for the largest share of India's manufacturing GVA?
Maharashtra, Gujarat, Tamil Nadu, Karnataka and Uttar Pradesh collectively account for over 54% of India's manufacturing GVA.

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions (PYQs)

Prelims

Q. In the 'Index of Eight Core Industries', which one of the following is given the highest weight? (2015)

(a) Coal production

(b) Electricity generation

(c) Fertilizer production

(d) Steel production

Ans: (b)

Mains

Q.1 "Industrial growth rate has lagged behind in the overall growth of Gross-Domestic-Product(GDP) in the post-reform period" Give reasons. How far the recent changes in Industrial Policy capable of increasing the industrial growth rate? **(2017)**

Q.2 Normally countries shift from agriculture to industry and then later to services, but India shifted directly from agriculture to services. What are the reasons for the huge growth of services vis-a-vis the industry in the country? Can India become a developed country without a strong industrial base? **(2014)**

Centre to Set Up Panel to Review UGC Equity Regulations, 2026

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Source: TH

The Central Government is contemplating setting up a special committee **to re-evaluate** the **University Grants Commission (Promotion of Equity in Higher Education Institutions) Regulations, 2026** , aiming to create a neutral framework that protects all students from discrimination.

- **Background:** The 2026 Regulations were formulated in response to the ongoing case ***Abeda Salim Tadvi v. Union of India (2019),*** which seeks to establish a mechanism to end caste-based discrimination on campuses.
- **Judicial Stay on 2026 Rules:** Following nationwide protests and legal challenges from various student groups, the **Supreme Court stayed the 2026 regulations** in January due to concerns over **vague**

provisions and possible misuse , temporarily restoring the older **2012 framework** .

- **UGC Equity Regulations, 2026:** The regulations aimed to eradicate discrimination on the basis of religion, race, caste, sex, or place of birth, and to promote equity and inclusion, particularly for **Scheduled Castes (SCs), Scheduled Tribes (STs), Socially and Educationally Backward Classes (SEBCs), and Economically Weaker Sections (EWS).**
  - **Key Provisions:**
    - **Institutional Mechanisms:** HEIs are required to establish an **Equal Opportunity Centre** and appoint an Ombudsperson to handle escalated grievances.
    - **Surveillance and Support:** The rules mandate the creation of an **Equity Helpline** .
      - They also proposed the formation of **mobile 'Equity Squads'** to monitor vulnerable spots on campuses and the designation of 'Equity Ambassadors' among stakeholders.
    - **Stricter Penalties:** The regulations provide for severe financial penalties and the potential withdrawal of UGC grants for institutions that fail to **comply with equity standards or ignore complaints of discrimination.**
- **Concerns:**
  - **Exclusion of General Category Students:** A primary objection to the regulations is that the grievance redressal mechanism **allegedly excludes general-category students.**
    - Critics argue this leaves non-reserved students without adequate recourse if they face discrimination or harassment.
  - **Potential Misuse** : The final regulations omitted a draft provision prescribing penalties for false discrimination complaints, prompting concerns about misuse and procedural fairness.
  - **Segregation and Fraternity:** The Court questioned whether separate arrangements in hostels, classrooms or mentorship groups could reinforce a **“separate but equal” framework, contrary to Articles 14 and 15 and constitutional fraternity.**
    - The Court emphasized that an anti-discrimination framework should not end up making any one section feel disadvantaged.
  - **Sub-classification Concerns:** The Court also questioned if the new rules adequately protect **Extremely Backward Castes** within the existing statutory sub-classification of SCs, STs, and OBCs against structural disadvantages.
  - **Omission of Ragging:** The Court also raised concerns about the absence of ragging as an explicitly recognised form of discrimination and its potential implications for **Articles 14 and 21.**

Read more: **Supreme Court Stays UGC's 2026 Regulations**

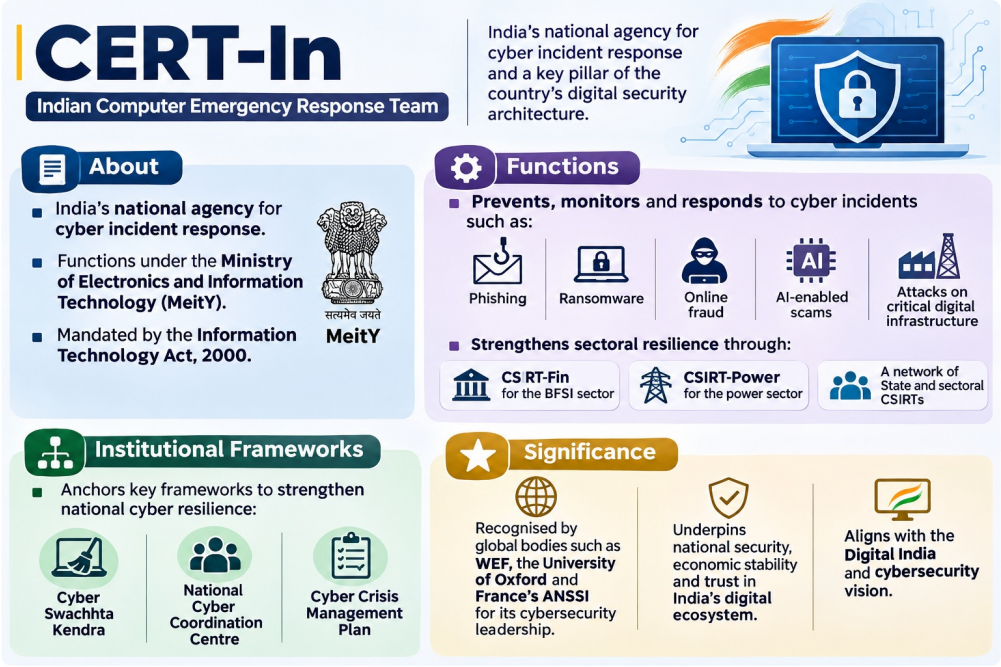
CERT-In Artificial Intelligence Security Auditing Guidelines

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Source:TH

The **Indian Computer Emergency Response Team (CERT-In)** has issued **the "Artificial Intelligence (AI) Security Auditing Guidelines,"** establishing a comprehensive framework to regulate, monitor, and audit the emerging risks associated with **agentic AI systems** and their autonomous capabilities.

- **Defining Agentic AI:** Unlike traditional Generative AI, which primarily responds to user prompts with text, images, or code, Agentic AI refers to autonomous artificial intelligence systems capable of taking independent actions to achieve designated goals.
  - These "agents" can interact with other software, execute commands, browse the internet, and manipulate files with minimal human intervention.
- **CERT-In's AI Security Auditing Guidelines:**
  - **Risk-Tiering System:** The guidelines classifies AI systems into **four risk tiers (Low, Moderate, High, and Critical)** based on impact severity, data sensitivity, and decision-making autonomy, which dictates the required depth, frequency, and independence of the audit.
  - **Comprehensive Audit Domains:** Encompasses **nine core domains** covering the entire AI lifecycle, prominently including **AI Governance, Data Privacy, Model Risk Management, Bias and Fairness, Explainability, Continuous Monitoring, Human Oversight and Supply-Chain Assurance.**
  - **Emerging Tech Safeguards:** Mandates dedicated security protocols for advanced architectures like **Generative AI, Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG),** and **Agentic AI** to proactively mitigate critical threats like prompt injection, data/model poisoning, and misinformation.
  - **Human-in-the-Loop:** While AI-assisted audit procedures are permitted for evidence analysis, they are strictly subject to confidentiality controls, tool validation, and competent human review.
    - AI outputs **cannot replace an auditor's independent judgment** .
  - **Strategic Alignment:** The guidelines are highly interoperable, aligning with **MeitY's India AI Governance Guidelines under 2025, under the IndiaAI Mission** , and global standards like **ISO/IEC 42001** .
    - ISO/IEC 42001, published in 2023, is the world's first international standard for an **Artificial Intelligence Management System (AIMS),** jointly developed by the **International Organization for Standardization (ISO) and the International Electrotechnical Commission (IEC)** .
  - **Seven Guiding Principles:** The foundation of the framework rests on principles vital to India's digital policy: **Security-by-Design, Accountability and Human Oversight, Transparency, Fairness, Data Privacy, and Auditability.**



Read more: India's Blueprint for AI Regulation

India Announces $500 Million Line of Credit for Guyana

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Source: DD

India announced a **USD 500 million Line of Credit (LoC) for road infrastructure, healthcare and defence projects in Guyana** on the sidelines of the **Commonwealth Heads of Government Meeting (CHOGM) 2026 in Antigua and Barbuda.**

- **Development Financing:** The **USD 500 million LoC will support Guyana's infrastructure and development priorities,** building on cooperation following the **Indian Prime Minister's visit in November 2024.**
  - A Line of Credit (LoC) is a financing arrangement that enables a partner country to access funds for agreed projects, generally under specified repayment conditions.
- **Three Bilateral Agreements:**
  - **Micro and Small Enterprises (MSEs):** Supply and installation of manufacturing projects to promote entrepreneurship and employment.
  - **Quick Impact Projects (QIPs):** Indian grant assistance for community-level development initiatives.
  - **Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI):** Cooperation to establish a UPI-like digital payment system in

Guyana, with Indian technical support.

- **Digital Cooperation:** Guyana aims to launch the **UPI- like payment system** by the end of 2026, with over 20 Guyanese personnel expected to receive training in India's UPI ecosystem.
- **Broader Partnership:** Both countries reviewed cooperation in **trade, energy, agriculture, infrastructure and capacity-building,** reflecting their shared priorities as Commonwealth members and Global South partners.
- **Strategic Importance:** Guyana's expanding offshore petroleum sector and its position within CARICOM make it an important partner for **India's engagement with the Caribbean and the Global South.**

Guyana

- **Location:** Guyana is situated on the northern coast of South America, bordered by **Venezuela (west), Brazil (south), Suriname (east) and the Atlantic Ocean (north).**
- **Capital and Official Language: Georgetown is the capital, and English is the official language,** making Guyana the only South American country with English as its official language.
- **Membership:** Member of the **Commonwealth of Nations** and the **Caribbean Community (CARICOM)** .



Read More: **PM's Visit to Nigeria, Brazil and Guyana**

Immigration and Foreigners (Exemption) Amendment Order, 2026

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Source: TH

The **Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA)** notified the Immigration and **Foreigners (Exemption) (Amendment) Order, 2026** , revising passport and visa exemptions for specified foreign nationals, including religious minorities from **Afghanistan, Bangladesh and Pakistan, Tibetan refugees, Sri Lankan Tamils** and certain long-term foreign residents.

- **Legal Framework:** The amendment modifies the **Immigration and Foreigners (Exemption) Order, 2025** , issued under the **Immigration and Foreigners Act, 2025.**
- **Visa Requirement for Religious Minorities:** Applies to **Hindus, Sikhs, Buddhists, Jains, Parsis and Christians from Afghanistan, Bangladesh and Pakistan** who entered India on or before 31st December 2024 due to religious persecution or fear of such persecution.
  - The exemption from possessing valid passports or visas at the time of entry is retained, but an appropriate category of visa is now mandatory for continued stay in India.
- **Visa Manual:** Formally defines the **Visa Manual as instructions issued by the Central Government concerning visas, immigration and related matters** .
- **Travel Between India, Nepal and Bhutan:**
  - Indian, Nepali and Bhutanese citizens travelling between these countries must produce identity documents prescribed in the Visa Manual before immigration authorities.
  - Indian citizens travelling to or returning from third countries through Nepal or Bhutan must possess valid passports and use designated immigration posts.
  - Nepali and Bhutanese citizens entering or exiting India from/to countries other than Nepal or Bhutan require valid passports. Those arriving after embarkation or transit through **China, Macau, Hong Kong or Pakistan** require both valid passports and visas.
- **Tibetan Refugees:** Retains passport and visa exemptions for Tibetans who entered **India after 1959 with an Entry Permit (before 30th May 2003)** or a Special Entry Permit (thereafter), subject to prescribed registration requirements.
- **Sri Lankan Tamil Refugees:** Registered Sri Lankan Tamil nationals **who took shelter in India up to 9th January 2015** remain exempt from specified passport and visa requirements for entry, stay and exit, subject to registration with designated Central or State Government officers.
- **Other Exempted Categories:** Includes specified military personnel, long-term Pakistani residents, Partition-era migrants and certain persons of Indian origin facing passport-renewal difficulties, subject to applicable conditions.

Difference Between the 2026 Amendment and CAA, 2019

Basis	2026 Amendment Order	Citizenship (Amendment) Act, 2019
Purpose	Regulates entry exemptions and visa requirements for continued stay	Provides a special pathway to Indian citizenship
Cut-off Date	31st December 2024	31st December 2014
Communities	Hindus, Sikhs, Buddhists, Jains, Parsis and Christians	Same six communities
Countries	Afghanistan, Bangladesh and Pakistan	Same three countries
Legal Effect	Requires an appropriate visa for continued stay while retaining specified exemptions	Facilitates citizenship subject to statutory eligibility conditions

Read More: Immigration and Foreigners Act, 2025

NASA's Swift Space Telescope Re-enters Earth's Atmosphere

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Source: DD

NASA's Neil Gehrels Swift Observatory , a space telescope dedicated to studying **gamma-ray bursts (GRBs) and other high-energy cosmic phenomena,** re-entered Earth's atmosphere over North Sumatra, Indonesia, on 4th November 2026, ending its 22-year mission.

- **Atmospheric Re-entry:** The **approximately 1,452-kg satellite re-entered Earth's atmosphere at around 22 times the speed of sound** , with most of its structure expected to burn up due to atmospheric heating.
- NASA reported no injuries or damage from falling debris.
- **Mission Background:** Launched in **2004, the observatory was designed for a two-year mission but remained operational for nearly 22 years** , ceasing scientific operations on 20th October 2026.
- **Primary Objective:** To detect and study gamma-ray bursts, among the most energetic explosions in the universe, using observations across multiple wavelengths. Swift could **rapidly redirect its**

telescopes within about a minute to observe the fading afterglows of gamma-ray bursts.

- **Scientific Instruments:** Swift carried three complementary telescopes:
  - **Burst Alert Telescope (BAT):** Detects gamma-ray bursts and determines their approximate locations.
  - **X-Ray Telescope (XRT):** Observes X-ray emissions and afterglows associated with cosmic explosions.
  - **Ultraviolet/Optical Telescope (UVOT):** Studies ultraviolet and visible-light emissions from astronomical sources.
- **Scientific Contributions:** Swift observed over **2,000 gamma-ray bursts and 1,400 supernovae, alongside black holes, stellar X-ray flares, asteroids and comets,** contributing to approximately 7,000 scientific publications.
- **Unsuccessful Orbit-Raising Attempt: Katalyst Space launched the LINK spacecraft in July 2026,** under a NASA-funded mission to capture Swift and raise its orbit.
  - However, propulsion and attitude-control failures prevented the planned orbital adjustment.
- **Cause of Re-entry:** Swift lacked an onboard propulsion system to maintain or raise its orbit, making it vulnerable to gradual orbital decay caused by atmospheric drag.



Read More: NASA Invites ISRO to Join Moon Base Programme